

Shunaska

A Constructed Language Without Grammatical Exceptions

Language Design and Development

June 5, 2026

Contents

1	Introduction	3
1.1	Motivation	3
1.2	Fundamental Principles	3
2	Phonology and Orthography	4
2.1	Alphabet	4
2.2	Syllable Structure	4
2.3	Tonic Accent	5
3	Morphology	5
3.1	Word Formation	5
3.2	Plural	5
3.3	Gender	6
3.4	Filiation	6
3.5	Possessive	6
3.6	Agent	7
3.7	Adverbs	7
4	The Verbification System	7
4.1	The Ten Verbification Suffixes	7
4.2	Complete Example: krag (fire)	7
4.3	Complete Example: vik (eye)	8
4.4	Nominalization	8
5	Syntax	8
5.1	Basic Structure	8
5.2	Personal Pronouns	9
5.3	Temporal Markers and Aspect	9
5.4	Negation	10
5.5	Articles and Demonstratives	10
5.6	Quantifiers	11
5.7	Interrogatives	11
5.8	Copula	12
5.9	Complement Order	12

6	Advanced Grammar	12
6.1	Relative Clauses	12
6.2	Reflexive Transitivity	13
6.3	Modals	13
6.4	Opposition	14
6.5	Comparison	14
6.6	Synonym Roots	14
7	Conjunctions and Prepositions	15
7.1	Conjunctions	15
7.2	Spatial Prepositions	15
7.3	Temporal Prepositions	15
7.4	Causal, Accompaniment, and Comparison Prepositions	16
8	Numeration	16
9	Vocabulary	17
9.1	Core Lexical Roots	17
9.2	Living Beings	18
9.3	Emotions and Psychological States	19
9.4	Social Relations	20
9.5	Essential Vocabulary Reference	20
10	Comparison with Other Constructed Languages	20
10.1	Positioning	20
10.2	vs. Esperanto	20
10.3	vs. Toki Pona	21
10.4	vs. Lojban	21
10.5	vs. Klingon	21
10.6	vs. Quenya	22
10.7	vs. High Valyrian	22
11	Practical Examples	23
11.1	Greetings and Everyday Expressions	23
11.2	Continuous vs. Completed Aspect	23
11.3	Progressive Complexity	23
11.4	Relative Clauses	24
11.5	Living Beings and Nature	24
11.6	Emotions and Abstract Sentences	24
12	Registers and Natural Evolution	24
12.1	Three Registers	24
12.2	The Language Shunaska Does Not Yet Have	25
12.3	On Atomic Roots	25
13	Conclusion and Future Directions	26

Abstract

Shunaska is a constructed language whose formal layer is free of grammatical exceptions. Its morphology is regular, its phonology predictable, and its syntax free of agreement rules. Three design decisions distinguish it from existing conlangs: (1) a system of ten verbification suffixes enabling fine semantic nuance with any noun root; (2) a **continuous-by-default** aspect—every verb expresses an ongoing action unless the suffix **-mak** explicitly marks completion; and (3) agglutinative transparency, where compound words reveal their meaning through visible roots—while atomic roots without compositional origin are equally legitimate. The grammar described here is a reference layer; like any language intended for speech, Shunaska is expected to evolve through use, developing registers, contractions, and organic exceptions that no designer could have anticipated.

1 Introduction

1.1 Motivation

Natural languages carry irregular verbs, arbitrary gender, exceptional plurals, and case systems whose complexity adds cognitive load without adding meaning. Constructed languages like Esperanto reduce but do not eliminate these irregularities. Shunaska's formal layer eliminates them: the reference grammar has no designed exceptions.

The language is grounded in the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis—the structure of a language shapes the way its speakers think. By making composition available (**azureima** = **azu** (doctor) + **reima** (mind) = psychologist), Shunaska makes analytical thought accessible: the speaker can *construct* meaning rather than passively receive it. That said, not every word needs to be compositionally derived. Atomic roots—**shka** (cat), **domak** (dog), **drusk** (oak)—are equally legitimate. Systematic derivation at all costs would produce words that are too long, too similar in sound, or too fragile when new concepts emerge.

A secondary ambition governs the phonological identity of Shunaska: the language aims for a **guttural, physical quality** reminiscent of the oldest known languages. Ancient Sumerian—the earliest attested agglutinative language—and Akkadian—a Semitic language rich in uvular and pharyngeal consonants—serve as aesthetic references. Like Sumerian, Shunaska is built on agglutinative roots that compose transparently. Like Akkadian, it favors consonant clusters and back-of-throat articulations that give speech a concrete, grounded weight. Yet where these ancient languages accumulated centuries of irregular forms through use, Shunaska starts from a regular base—knowing that speakers will shape it from there.

1.2 Fundamental Principles

1. **Designed regularity:** The formal layer has no grammatical exceptions. This reference grammar is the starting point, not a permanent constraint: any living language evolves through use.
2. **Transparency where useful:** Compound words reveal their internal structure in formal register. Atomic roots without compositional origin are equally valid and prevent phonetic crowding and excessive word length.
3. **Semantic logic:** Grammatical markers encode meaning, not convention.

4. **Gender neutrality:** Gender is optional and marked only when necessary.
5. **Continuous default:** All tenses express ongoing actions by default; completion is explicitly marked with **-mak**.
6. **Minimalism:** Forms are as short as possible without sacrificing precision.
7. **Openness to evolution:** The best linguistic changes are those the designer did not anticipate. Speakers will reveal which words are too long to chain, which constructions sound unnatural, and which contractions impose themselves. This is not a flaw—it is how languages become real.

2 Phonology and Orthography

2.1 Alphabet

Shunaska uses **21 letters**: 5 vowels (A, E, I, O, U) and 16 consonants (B, D, F, G, J, K, L, M, N, P, R, S, Sh, T, V, Z). Each letter has a single invariant pronunciation, ensuring that a written word can always be pronounced correctly and a spoken word can always be written without ambiguity.

Letter	IPA	Example	Letter	IPA	Example
A	[a]	<i>father</i>	M	[m]	<i>mother</i>
B	[b]	<i>boy</i>	N	[n]	<i>night</i>
D	[d]	<i>day</i>	O	[o]	<i>go</i>
E	[e]	<i>say</i>	P	[p]	<i>papa</i>
F	[f]	<i>fall</i>	R	[R]	<i>fr. riz</i> (uvular)
G	[g]	<i>go</i>	S	[s]	<i>science</i>
I	[i]	<i>see</i>	Sh	[S]	<i>shoe</i>
J	[Z]	<i>measure</i>	T	[t]	<i>tea</i>
K	[k]	<i>kiwi</i>	U	[u]	<i>blue</i>
L	[l]	<i>light</i>	V	[v]	<i>vain</i>
			Z	[z]	<i>zero</i>

2.2 Syllable Structure

Syllables follow three patterns:

- **CVC:** **tak** (tool/instrument), **val** (water)
- **CV:** **ka** (and), **na** (he/she/it)
- **CCV:** **tsha** (door), **krag** (fire), **drun** (ground/soil)

Words generally contain 1 to 4 syllables. When composition produces a double letter, the second is replaced by an apostrophe: **gaddin** → **gad'in** (hello).

2.3 Tonic Accent

The stress rule is **invariable**: stress falls on the *first vowel of the first root* in a compound word.

- **IA** (I), **SHU**naska, **VAL**movak (fish), **AZU**reima (psychologist)
- **KRA**gshar (to burn), **FOR**vnav (fruit), **DRU**nkrav (mountain)

Tense markers (a-, e-, u-, i-, o-, e-mak, etc.) carry **no stress**; the accent remains on the first root:

```
ia SHAI'shar = I am eating (stress on shai')
ia a-SHAI'shar = I am eating (present continuous)
ia e-SHAI'shar = I was eating (past continuous)
ia e-mak SHAI'shar = I ate (past completed)
```

3 Morphology

3.1 Word Formation

Shunaska is highly agglutinative. Complex concepts are built by joining roots and suffixes whose meanings are always transparent:

- azureima = azu (doctor) + reima (mind) = *psychologist*
- drunkrav = drun (ground/soil) + krav (imposing force) = *mountain*
- valalaku = val (water) + alaku (to go) = *river*
- druvik = dru (night/darkness) + vik (eye) = *owl*
- dubrig = dub (mouth) + rig (tooth) = *mastication*

3.2 Plural

The suffix **-ene** marks the plural uniformly for all nouns and pronouns:

Singular	Plural	English
shka	shkaene	cat / cats
lufi	lufiene	child / children
ia	iaene	I / we
ra	raene	you (sg.) / you (pl.)
na	naene	he / she / they

3.3 Gender

Shunaska is **gender-neutral by default**. Gender suffixes apply only to natural entities (living beings) when distinction is necessary:

- **-o**: masculine — **shkao** (male cat), **luoni** (father)
- **-a**: feminine — **shka'** (female cat), **luani** (mother)
- **neutral**: no suffix — **shka** (cat), **luni** (parent)

Gender marking adds morphological complexity, which deliberately encourages use of the neutral form.

3.4 Filiation

Descent and ascent are marked by regular suffixes that compose with numbers:

- **-fi**: descent — **lufi** (child), **shkafi** (kitten)
- **-ni**: ascent — **luni** (parent), **shkani** (cat's parent)

Adding a number extends the degree:

Word	Meaning
luni	parent
lunidu	grandparent (du = 2)
lunitu	great-grandparent (tu = 3)
lufi	child
lufidu	grandchild

3.5 Possessive

Possession is expressed by the invariable word **do**, placed between the possessed and the possessor. The structure is always: **[possessed] + do + [possessor]**. **do** covers all forms of the genitive: *my, your, his, her, their, of the...*

```
shka do ia = my cat (cat of me)
shkaene do ia = my cats
enki shka do ia = the cat of mine (with definite article)
enki do ia = mine (implicit: we know what is meant)
shka do na = his/her cat
shka do naene = their cat
shai' do shka = the cat's meal (meal of the cat)
enki shai' do shkaene = the cats' meal
tru do oden do ia = my friend's house (house of friend of me)
```

do systematically replaces all genitive constructions. The logic is invariable: possessed first, **do** as the link, possessor last. Note: **do** is the possession marker only; **du** is the number 2.

3.6 Agent

The suffix **-ar** derives an agent noun from any verb:

- **vikbuk** (to read) → **vikbukar** (reader)
- **dubshar** (to speak) → **dubsharar** (speaker)
- **nolshar** (to study) → **nolsharar** (student)

3.7 Adverbs

Any adjective becomes an adverb via the suffix **-ni**:

- **gal** (great/important) → **galni** (greatly)
- **sur** (small, gentle) → **surni** (gently)
- **daka** (very) is an adverb of intensity

4 The Verbification System

4.1 The Ten Verbification Suffixes

The central innovation of Shunaska is a closed set of ten suffixes that convert any noun into a verb, each carrying a precise semantic nuance. This eliminates the need for separate verb roots for related concepts.

Suffix	Category	Meaning
-va	suffer / receive	undergone, involuntary action
-shar	act voluntarily	intentional, deliberate action
-kru	produce / emit	to produce, generate
-skur	transform	to modify the state of
-lak	displace	movement, propagation
-zor	cause / provoke	to trigger, initiate
-mur	become	gradual state change
-dru	repeat / iterate	continuous or repeated action
-fen	exchange / interact	reciprocal or shared action
-nek	exist / state	to be in a stable state

4.2 Complete Example: krag (fire)

- **kragva**: to be burned (involuntary)
- **kragshar**: to burn deliberately
- **kragkru**: to ignite, produce fire
- **kragskur**: to calcine, transform by fire
- **kraglak**: to spread (fire propagating)

- **kragzor**: to set fire to, trigger an ignition
- **kragmur**: to blaze, become inflamed gradually
- **kragdru**: to crackle (repeated action)
- **kragfen**: to share a flame (reciprocal)
- **kragnek**: to smolder, be in a state of fire

4.3 Complete Example: **vik** (eye)

- **vikva**: to perceive, to catch sight of (involuntary)
- **vikshar**: to look at (deliberate)
- **vikkru**: to emit a gaze, to stare
- **vikskur**: to hypnotize, to transform through gaze
- **viklak**: to scan, to sweep with the eyes
- **vikzor**: to aim, to target visually
- **vikmur**: to appear, to become visible
- **vikdru**: to watch, to observe continuously
- **vikfen**: to exchange a glance
- **viknek**: to be visible, to exist in sight

4.4 Nominalization

Any verb can be converted back into a noun via the suffix **-im**:

- **kragdru** (to crackle) → **kragdruim** (crackling)
- **kragzor** (to set fire to) → **kragzorim** (ignition, arson)
- **vikfen** (to exchange a glance) → **vikfenim** (an exchange of glances)
- **nolshar** (to study) → **nolsharim** (the act of studying)

5 Syntax

5.1 Basic Structure

Shunaska follows a strict **Subject – Verb – Complement (SVC)** order. Adjectives follow the noun they modify. There is no agreement: no inflection for number, gender, or case.

ia shai'shar = I am eating
 ra vikshar na = you are watching him/her
 naene u-tak shai' = they will be preparing a meal
 shka gal = big cat (adjective after noun)
 enki shkaene gal = the big cats (no agreement)

5.2 Personal Pronouns

Shunaska	English
ia	I
ra	you (singular)
na	he / she / it (neutral, preferred)
nao	he / him (masculine explicit)
na'	she / her (feminine explicit)
ta / taene	one / one (plural)
iaene	we
raene	you (plural)
naene	they (neutral)

5.3 Temporal Markers and Aspect

Shunaska has **no verbal conjugation**. Tense is marked by a prefix attached to the verb with a hyphen. The present marker **a-** may be omitted.

Continuous by default

All tenses express **ongoing, continuous actions by default**. This reflects natural language use: saying “I eat” means in practice “I am eating.” No marker is required to indicate continuity.

Completed aspect: -mak

To indicate that an action is **finished and complete**, the suffix **-mak** is added to the tense marker. This is the only way to express completion.

Tense	Continuous (default)	Completed (-mak)
Present	a- (or omitted)	a-mak
Past	e-	e-mak
Future	u-	u-mak
Conditional	i-	i-mak
Imperative	o-	—

ia shai'shar = I am eating (present continuous, default)
 ia a-shai'shar = I am eating (present explicit)
 ia e-shai'shar = I was eating (past continuous)
 ia e-mak shai'shar = I ate (past completed)
 ia u-shai'shar = I will be eating (future continuous)

```

ia u-mak shai'shar = I will have eaten (future completed)
ia i-shai'shar = I would be eating (conditional continuous)
ia i-mak shai'shar = I would have eaten (conditional completed)
o-shai'shar = Eat! (imperative)

```

The contrast between continuous and completed reflects a real cognitive distinction: *ia e-shai'shar* (I was in the middle of eating) vs. *ia e-mak shai'shar* (I ate, it is done).

Temporal nuances

The modifiers *ok* (near) and *go* (far) compound with tense markers for greater precision:

Marker	Meaning	Example
<i>eok</i>	near past (continuous)	<i>shka eok shai'shar</i> = the cat was just eating
<i>eok-mak</i>	near past (completed)	<i>shka eok-mak shai'shar</i> = the cat just ate
<i>ego</i>	distant past (continuous)	<i>shka ego shai'shar</i> = the cat was eating long ago
<i>ego-mak</i>	distant past (completed)	<i>shka ego-mak shai'shar</i> = the cat had eaten long ago
<i>uok</i>	near future (continuous)	<i>shka uok shai'shar</i> = the cat will soon be eating
<i>uok-mak</i>	near future (completed)	<i>shka uok-mak shai'shar</i> = the cat will soon have eaten
<i>ugo</i>	distant future (continuous)	<i>shka ugo shai'shar</i> = the cat will be eating someday

5.4 Negation

Simple negation: *ul* before the verb.

- *ra ul shai'shar* = you are not eating
- *ia ul e-mak vikshar na* = I did not see him/her

Change of state (no longer): *vin* before the verb, indicating a transition from a previous state.

- *ra vin dubshar* = you are no longer speaking
- *ia vin dalek shka* = I no longer have a cat
- *naene vin evok komia* = they are no longer well

5.5 Articles and Demonstratives

- **Indefinite:** no marker (the absence of specification is expressed by silence)
- **Definite:** *enki* (invariable, precedes the noun)
- **Proximal:** *enkiok* (this, near the speaker)
- **Distal:** *enkigo* (that, far from the speaker)

```
shka = a cat
enki shka = the cat
enkiok shka = this cat (here, nearby)
enkigo shka = that cat (over there)
enki shkaene = the cats (enki does not inflect)
```

5.6 Quantifiers

Word	Meaning
kanin	numerous
kanu	a lot of
dorin	several
doru	a few
duno	each, every
solka	all
zukan	none

```
zukan shka disok = no cat around here
kanin shkaene shai'shar = numerous cats are eating
duno lufi nol = every child is learning
```

5.7 Interrogatives

Yes/no questions begin with to. Interrogative pronouns replace to and carry the question inherently:

Word	Meaning
to	question marker (yes/no)
mekto	how?
akto	why?
sto	who?
deto	where?
kto	what?
futo	which?
kanto	how many?
euto	when?

```
To ra shai'shar? = Are you eating?
Deto ia e-mak alaku? = Where did I go?
Sto e-mak vikshar na? = Who saw him/her?
Kanto ra dalek shkaene? = How many cats do you have?
```

5.8 Copula

Two forms of “to be” exist:

- **sekan**: long-term, stable identity (*na sekan shka* = it is a cat)
- **evok**: short-term, current state (*ia evok komia* = I am well)

Both are **optional at the present tense** when the meaning is clear: *na sekan shka* = *na shka*.

5.9 Complement Order

With multiple complements, the order is **free but generally of decreasing importance**. Temporal complements may be fronted:

Dinu ia tak shai' dak druv dja lufi.

= Tomorrow I will be preparing the meal in the forest with a child.

(*dinu* = tomorrow, fronted for temporal framing)

ia tak shai' dja lufi dak druv.

= I am preparing the meal with the child in the forest.

(child is more important than location)

6 Advanced Grammar

6.1 Relative Clauses

Relative clauses use five markers that encode the grammatical role of the relativized element:

Marker	Role	Meaning
<i>ki</i>	subject relative	the X <i>that</i> (subject of the clause)
<i>ze</i>	object relative	the X <i>that</i> (object of the clause)
<i>ko</i>	locative relative	the X <i>where</i>
<i>eu</i>	temporal relative	the X <i>when</i>
<i>ak</i>	causal relative	the X <i>because</i> / <i>why</i>

-- Subject relative (*ki*)

shka ki e-mak shai'shar iu shka

= the cat that ate a cat (cat = subject of "eating")

lufiene ki u-nol dak kal

= the children who will be learning at school

-- Object relative (*ze*)

shka ze ia e-mak shai'shar

= the cat that I ate (cat = object of "I ate")

druv ze ia e-vikshar na duv dina

```

= the forest that I was observing all day

-- Locative relative (ko)
tru ko ia dalek
= the house where I live

kal ko naene nol
= the school where they are learning

-- Temporal relative (eu)
din eu ra e-mak alaku
= the day when you left

-- Causal relative (ak)
raison ak ia e-mak alaku
= the reason why I left (literally: the reason because I left)

-- Chained relatives
shka ze ia e-mak shai'shar, ki e-mak shai'shar iu shka
= the cat that I ate, which had eaten a cat

```

6.2 Reflexive Transitivity

The marker *akti* indicates that the action is directed at oneself:

- *ra shai'shar akti* = you eat yourself
- *naene kamu akti* = they agglomerate (themselves)
- *na e-alaku akti* = he/she was taking himself/herself away

6.3 Modals

Word	Meaning
<i>gul</i>	to want
<i>gulkar</i>	to desire (stronger)
<i>le'u</i>	to be able to (capacity)
<i>zin</i>	to have permission
<i>tor</i>	must, to have to
<i>lem</i>	it is possible that
<i>vak</i>	to intend to
<i>gru</i>	it is necessary that

```

ia gul shai'shar = I want to eat
ia le'u dubshar = I am able to speak
ia tor nol = I must learn
ia ul zin alaku = I do not have permission to go
lem na u-shai'shar dja ia = it is possible that he will be eating with me

```

6.4 Opposition

The word **an** forms the opposite of any word. This is distinct from negation: “not near” does not necessarily mean “far.”

- **ok** (near) → **an ok** (far) — cf. **ul ok** (not near, which may be intermediate)
- **gal** (great) → **an gal** (insignificant, opposite of great)
- **komia** (well) → **an komia** (unwell, the opposite of well)

6.5 Comparison

Comparative — comparison between two elements:

- **moto** = more
- **suko** = less
- **ono** = as much

Superlative — add **enki**:

- **enki moto gal** = the greatest
- **enki suko gal** = the least great

“**Than**” — use **ze** (the relational marker):

na sekan moto gal ze ra = he/she is greater than you
enki shka sekan moto grav ze shka do na
 = that cat is heavier than his/her cat

6.6 Synonym Roots

Shunaska distinguishes near-synonym roots that share a semantic domain but differ in precise nuance. This forces the speaker to consciously choose the exact meaning:

Domain	Root 1	Nuance	Root 2 / Nuance
Hot	vrak	external temperature, weather	varm : body warmth, internal heat
Cold	krul	cold (temperature)	zrak : viscous, reptilian cold
Big	gal	great in importance or value	grav : great in mass, raw size
Ground	drun	ground/soil	grom : depth, underground layer
Small	sur	small, gentle, delicate	smak : small, agile, quick
Long	slim	long and thin (horizontal)	lin : long and pointed (vertical)
Hand	tarak	the hand as organ	sem : dexterity, manual skill
Force	krav	imposing, visible power	gral : heaviness, crushing mass

Examples: **kravom** (lion = imposing force + creature), **valgravak** (whale = water + massive + animal), **semak** (monkey = dexterity + animal).

7 Conjunctions and Prepositions

7.1 Conjunctions

Word	Meaning	Type
ka	and	coordination
u	or	coordination
tem	but	coordination
kun	therefore	coordination
da	because	subordination
sok	if	subordination
eu	when	subordination
duv ze	while	subordination

7.2 Spatial Prepositions

Word	Meaning	Note
dak	in, inside	interior
kemo	on	surface contact
milo	under	contact below
rin	between	
ke	above	no contact
mi	below	no contact
ok	near	
go	far	
ruok	next to, beside	lateral proximity
elu	from	origin
ulu	towards	destination

7.3 Temporal Prepositions

Word	Meaning
leki	before
loku	after
duv	during
eudu	since
tu'n	until
arku	then, afterwards

7.4 Causal, Accompaniment, and Comparison Prepositions

Word	Meaning	Nuance
kron	because of	negative cause
sak	thanks to	positive cause
vora	for	purpose or recipient
dja	with	accompaniment
dja'n	without	absence
suma	like, as	similarity
luna	as (a role)	function or capacity
kuma	contrary to	opposition
ze	than	comparison

8 Numeration

A number is called **kan**. Numbers are built compositionally:

Number	Word	Number	Word
0	zu	10	shi
1	iu	11	shi'u
2	du	12	shidu
3	tu	20	dushi
4	ku	30	tushi
5	su	100	kin
6	lu	1 000	fa'n
7	gu	1 000 000	gain
8	ru	1 000 000 000	masrin
9	nu		

Examples: 256 = dukinsushilu; 1024 = fa'ndushiku.

Dates are expressed as pairs: the year 2026 is read as “20”-“26” = dushi dushilu.

9 Vocabulary

9.1 Core Lexical Roots

Natural Elements

Word	Meaning	Key Compounds
val	water	valgal (ocean), valk (rain), valrin (island)
krag	fire	kragshar (to burn), drunkrag (volcano)
drun	ground/soil (surface)	drunkrav (mountain), drunok (cave)
zif	air, wind	zifshar (to blow), zifgrak (storm)
grok	stone, rock	—
forv	wood, plant	forvgal (tree), forvnav (fruit), druv (forest)
pai'	star / sun	pai'ok (our sun)
melka	moon	melkaok (our moon)
shuga	sky	—
shuvak	space	—
din	day	dina (today), dine (yesterday), dinu (tomorrow)
nut	night	gadnut (good night)

Colors

Word	Color	Example
aro	red, warm	arokar (passionate heart)
pal	white, clear	palvik (clear eyes), zakpal (pale blue)
zak	blue	zakzif (blue sky)
grem	green	gremforv (green plant)
nok	black	nokdru (dark night), nokvik (raven)
sol	yellow	solpai' (yellow sun)
maz	brown	mazforv (brown tree)

Body and Perception

Word	Meaning	Key Compounds
vik	eye	vikshar (to look), vikdru (to watch continuously)
dub	mouth	dubshar (to speak), dubrig (mastication)
uk	ear	ukva (to hear), ukshar (to listen)
nosk	nose	—
tarak	hand (organ)	—
sem	manual dexterity	semak (monkey)
muf	foot	—
kar	heart	arokar (passion), shenkar (loving heart)
sek	brain	sekva (to know)
reima	mind, spirit	azureima (psychologist)
dren	blood	—
klan	bone, rigid structure	valklan (crab), zimklan (scarab)
droma	sleep	dromava (to sleep)

9.2 Living Beings

General Roots for Living Beings

- **ki**’ = life, living (general root)
- **movak** = animal, creature
- **forv** = plant, vegetation
- **fuvak** = fungus, mushroom
- **lu** = human

Animals by Category

The category of an animal is encoded in its root composition:

Category	Principle	Example	Translation
Mammal	var m (warm) + movak	varmovak	mammal
Bird	vuk (wing) + movak	vukmovak	bird
Reptile	krul (cold) + movak	krulmovak	reptile
Fish	val (water) + movak	valmovak	fish
Insect	zim (rapid wing)	zimmovak	insect
Amphibian	duv (dual/land-water)	duvmovak	amphibian

Selected animals and their compositional logic:

Word	Composition	Animal
shka	(atomic)	cat
domak	(atomic)	dog
kravom	krav (force) + creature	lion
dolvak	dol (wild) + animal	wolf
lonvak	lon (horn) + animal	stag
lonvak sur	lon + animal + sur (small)	doe
lufak	luf (wool) + animal	sheep
slimak	slim (long/thin) + animal	snake
grankul	gran (hard) + kul (shell)	tortoise
valgravak	val (water) + grav (massive) + animal	whale
valvuk	val (water) + vuk (wing)	duck
kravvuk	krav (power) + vuk (wing)	eagle
druvik	dru (night) + vik (eye)	owl
nokvik	nok (black) + vik (eye)	raven
semak	sem (dexterity) + animal	monkey
zimkru	zim (insect) + kru (produces)	bee
valgruf	val (water) + gruf (tentacle)	octopus
valklan	val (water) + klan (armor)	crab
valgruk	val (water) + gruk (croak)	frog

Plants

Category roots use **forv** as base. Individual species have their own roots—atomic or minimally compositional—so that not every plant name begins identically.

Category names: **forvgal** (tree), **forvruk** (flower), **forvnav** (fruit), **navgrom** (vegetable), **forvkru** (cereal), **forvdum** (aromatic herb), **forvsmak** (grass/small plant).

Word	Composition / Note	Plant
forvgal	forv + gal (great)	tree (category)
drusk	own root	oak
beliv	own root	birch
spirom	own root	fir
pinak	own root	pine
makrel	own root	maple
tilom	own root	linden
frask	own root	ash
forvruk	forv + ruk (colored)	flower (category)
rozak	own root	rose
tornpai	<i>torna</i> (turn) + pai (sun)	sunflower
forvnav	forv + nav (edible)	fruit (category)
melov	own root	apple
narunk	own root	orange
navgrom	nav (edible) + grom (underground)	vegetable (category)
korotiv	own root	carrot
spinak	own root	spinach
forvkru	forv + kru (grain)	cereal (category)
spik	own root	wheat
rizak	own root	rice

9.3 Emotions and Psychological States

Word	Meaning	Verbal form
jal	joy, happiness	jalshar (to rejoice)
pren	fear, anxiety	prenva (to be afraid)
gron	sadness	gronva (to feel sad)
mor	anger, rage	morshar (to get angry)
shen	love, affection	shenshar (to love)
ven	calm, serenity	vennek (to be calm)
nol	curiosity	nolshar (to be curious)
vol	pride	volshar (to feel proud)
gren	gratitude	grenkar (grateful heart)

9.4 Social Relations

Word	Meaning
oden	friend, companion
rim	enemy, rival
nik	neighbour
tal	group, community
mar	teacher, mentor
zom	apprentice, student
tarn	leader, authority
azu	doctor, healer
azureima	psychologist (azu + reima)

9.5 Essential Vocabulary Reference

Shunaska	English	Shunaska	English
gad'in	hello	sekan	to be (stable)
gadnut	good night	evok	to be (state)
ia	yes	dalek	to have
ania	no	alaku	to go
djakar	thank you	tak	to do / tool
dina	today	nol	to learn
dine	yesterday	trin	to create
dinu	tomorrow	ren	to breathe / live
shai'shar	to eat	zen	to die
valdubshar	to drink	dromava	to sleep
dubshar	to speak	gul	to want
vikshar	to look at	le'u	to be able
vikva	to see (involuntary)	tor	must
shai'	meal, food	tru	house
buk	book	kal	school
vikbuk	to read	dal	town, village

10 Comparison with Other Constructed Languages

10.1 Positioning

Shunaska occupies a unique position: it is neither a purely auxiliary language (Esperanto), nor a minimalist philosophy exercise (Toki Pona), nor a formal logic system (Lojban). Its goal is to train **compositional, analytical thinking** through morphological transparency and systematic regularity.

10.2 vs. Esperanto

Esperanto (Zamenhof, 1887) simplifies but does not eliminate natural language complexity:

Criterion	Esperanto	Shunaska
Verbal conjugation	Complex (6 tenses)	Absent (markers only)
Gender system	Binary, obligatory	Optional, neutral default
Cases	2 (nom./acc.)	None
Grammatical exceptions	Several	Zero
Morphological transparency	Medium	Maximum
Verb nuance system	Limited	10 suffixes
Continuous aspect	Explicit marker needed	Default

Shunaska advantage: simpler, more logical, compositionally transparent.

Esperanto advantage: established community, decades of literature.

10.3 vs. Toki Pona

Toki Pona (Craig Thomas, 2001) pursues radical minimalism with approximately 120 words. Nuance requires periphrasis, and precision must be sacrificed. Shunaska takes the opposite approach: a moderate vocabulary expandable through unlimited compositional agglutination, with ten verbification suffixes enabling fine semantic distinctions that would require entire phrases in Toki Pona.

Toki Pona advantage: extreme minimalism, easy initial acquisition.

Shunaska advantage: fine nuance, compositional richness, cognitive depth.

10.4 vs. Lojban

Lojban (Cowan et al., 1987) pursues absolute logical clarity through predicate logic grammar. Every sentence eliminates all ambiguity. While logically impeccable, Lojban is notoriously difficult to speak naturally and has a steep learning curve. Shunaska achieves clarity through regularity and transparency rather than formal rigor, producing a language that is simultaneously logical and natural.

Lojban advantage: absolute logical unambiguity.

Shunaska advantage: clarity + naturalness + learnability.

10.5 vs. Klingon

Klingon (Marc Okrand, 1984) was designed for *Star Trek* with the explicit goal of sounding alien and aggressive. It succeeds phonologically—ejective consonants, uvular stops, a harsh rhythmic quality—but its grammar was deliberately made irregular to feel foreign to human speakers.

Criterion	Klingon	Shunaska
Word order	OVS (Object-Verb-Subject)	SVC (universal)
Grammatical exceptions	Numerous	Zero
Gender system	None	Optional, neutral default
Verb nuance system	Limited	10 suffixes
Phonological identity	Harsh, guttural	Guttural (Sumerian/Akkadian palette)
Continuous aspect	Must be explicit	Default
Design purpose	Fictional alienness	Cognitive tool + daily use

Klingon and Shunaska share a guttural phonological aesthetic, but pursue opposite grammatical philosophies: Klingon maximizes foreignness through irregularity; Shunaska maximizes usability through regularity. The OVS word order of Klingon is among the rarest structures in human languages, making it cognitively costly. Shunaska uses SVC, the most common order across natural languages.

Klingon advantage: unique cultural identity, large fan community, extensive literature.

Shunaska advantage: learnable, regular, usable, natural word order.

10.6 vs. Quenya

Quenya (J.R.R. Tolkien, sketched from the 1910s) is arguably the most artistically accomplished constructed language ever created. Inspired by Finnish phonology, it is euphonic, vocalic, and deeply embedded in an invented mythology. However, it was designed as an aesthetic object, not a functional tool.

Criterion	Quenya	Shunaska
Noun cases	10	None
Verb conjugation	Person, tense, mood	None (markers only)
Grammatical exceptions	Many	Zero
Gender system	Present	Optional, neutral default
Phonological identity	Euphonic, vocalic	Guttural, consonantal
Modern concept coverage	Very limited	Fully compositional
Design purpose	Fictional aesthetics	Cognitive tool + daily use

Quenya's ten noun cases and complex verb system require years of study for fluency. Its vocabulary, rooted in Tolkien's mythology, has no systematic mechanism for generating new words to cover modern or technical domains. Shunaska's agglutinative composition handles any concept by combining known roots.

Quenya advantage: extraordinary aesthetic quality, rich mythology, literary prestige.

Shunaska advantage: learnable, exception-free, extensible to any domain.

10.7 vs. High Valyrian

High Valyrian (David J. Peterson, 2012) was developed for *Game of Thrones* and is one of the most grammatically complete fictional languages built for screen. It features a fully functional, if complex, grammar system.

Criterion	High Valyrian	Shunaska
Noun genders	4 (lunar, solar, terrestrial, aquatic)	None
Noun cases	8	None
Verb conjugation	Person, tense, mood, aspect	None (markers only)
Grammatical exceptions	Several	Zero
Design purpose	Cinematic aesthetics	Cognitive tool + daily use
Vocabulary coverage	Limited to show content	Fully compositional

High Valyrian’s four-gender noun system—where words are classified as lunar, solar, terrestrial, or aquatic—adds poetic flavour but serves no communicative function, imposing a memorization burden with no semantic payoff. Its eight cases rival Latin in complexity. Shunaska conveys all the same spatial and relational information through invariable prepositions and SVC order alone.

High Valyrian advantage: cinematic prestige, rich inflectional elegance, active learner community.

Shunaska advantage: no genders, no cases, zero exceptions, usable without a script.

11 Practical Examples

11.1 Greetings and Everyday Expressions

```
gad'in = hello (good + day)
gadnut = good night (good + night)
To ra evok komia? = How are you? (Are you in a good state?)
ia evok komia, djakar = I am well, thank you
ia ul evok komia = I am not well
```

11.2 Continuous vs. Completed Aspect

```
ia shai'shar = I am eating
ia e-shai'shar = I was eating (still ongoing in the past)
ia e-mak shai'shar = I ate (finished, completed)

shka e-vikshar oden do ia = the cat was watching my friend
shka e-mak vikshar oden do ia = the cat watched my friend (it is done)

ra u-nol dak kal = you will be learning at school
ra u-mak nol dak kal = you will have finished learning at school
```

11.3 Progressive Complexity

```
-- Simple
ia shai'shar
  = I am eating

-- Intermediate
ia e-shai'shar dak druv dja oden
  = I was eating in the forest with a friend

-- Complex
Enki lufi ze ia e-mak ilu na, ki u-nol kal dja mar gal, sekan moto jal.
  = The child that I imagined, who will be learning at school with
    a great teacher, is happier.
    (ilu = to imagine; mar gal = great teacher)
```

11.4 Relative Clauses

shka ki e-mak shai'shar iu shka
= the cat that ate a cat

shka ze ia e-mak shai'shar
= the cat that I ate

tru ko ia dalek
= the house where I live

din eu ra e-mak alaku ulu dal
= the day when you left for the town

raison ak ia e-mak alaku
= the reason why I left

11.5 Living Beings and Nature

enki kravom e-shai'shar dolvak dak druv
= the lion was eating a wolf in the forest

vukmovakene ki u-alaku ulu shuga
= the birds that will be flying towards the sky

enki druvik vikdru tru do ia
= the owl is watching my house continuously

enkiok drusk sekan moto grav ze enkigo pinak
= this oak is heavier than that pine

11.6 Emotions and Abstract Sentences

ia shenshar enki shka ki jalshar dak tru do ia
= I love the cat that is rejoicing in my house

ra e-mak tak ipshu gal, kun ia evok vol
= you did something very complex, therefore I feel proud

gru nol, sok ra gul sekan mar
= it is necessary to learn, if you want to be a teacher

12 Registers and Natural Evolution

12.1 Three Registers

Like any language intended for speech, Shunaska anticipates three natural registers that will emerge through use:

Formal register Always transparent. Words are composed according to the reference grammar; their internal structure is always visible. This is the Shunaska of dictionaries, texts, and formal exchange. It is what this paper describes.

Everyday register Contracted forms, lexical shortcuts, words that have “fallen into use” as standalone items. A speaker will naturally say *mentik* (mint) rather than assembling a compositional description each time. Short phonetic hints replace full compositions. This register emerges spontaneously and is entirely legitimate.

Familiar register Colloquial forms, nascent slang, fixed expressions, affective distortions. The inevitable result of a community of speakers who develop a shared language.

These registers are not a compromise of the design; they are its natural extension. A language that has only a formal register has no speakers.

12.2 The Language Shunaska Does Not Yet Have

At the time of writing, Shunaska has no regular speakers, and therefore no established contractions, no confirmed exceptions, no settled collocations. This is a design state, not a final state.

The reference grammar described here provides a stable foundation. Speakers will reveal what the designer could not predict:

- Which words are too long to chain in natural speech
- Which sound combinations create ambiguity at normal speaking speed
- Which constructions feel natural and which resist use
- Which shortcuts impose themselves until they become standard

The best linguistic changes are those the creator did not anticipate. Shunaska does not aim to be a finished product. It aims to be a coherent starting point from which a real language can grow.

12.3 On Atomic Roots

Not every word in Shunaska is or should be compositionally derived. Systematic derivation at all costs produces:

- Words that are phonetically too similar, causing confusion in speech
- Compounds that are too long to chain fluently
- A system too rigid to absorb new concepts (a newly discovered species, a new technology, a new emotion)

Atomic roots—*shka* (cat), *domak* (dog), *saltik* (rabbit), *drusk* (oak), *narunk* (orange)—are not exceptions to the system. They are a feature of the system. Transparency is an option available to speakers, not an obligation enforced on every word. When a new reality appears, giving it a new independent name is as valid as deriving one from existing roots.

13 Conclusion and Future Directions

Shunaska demonstrates that a language can be simultaneously regular, transparent, and expressive. Its central innovations reinforce each other: the ten verbification suffixes produce fine nuance without irregular roots; the continuous-by-default aspect reflects how language is actually used in speech; and the agglutinative structure makes compositional meaning available without making it mandatory.

Unlike Esperanto, Shunaska requires no conjugation. Unlike Toki Pona, it does not sacrifice nuance for simplicity. Unlike Lojban, it preserves naturalism without sacrificing regularity. It stands not as a competitor to these languages but as a tool for a different purpose: providing a coherent, learnable base that speakers can inhabit, reshape, and make their own.

The reference grammar presented here is a starting point. Its regularity is an asset for learning, not a wall against change. The absence of designed exceptions means that every rule learned applies everywhere at the formal layer—but the language knows it will be spoken, contracted, and surprised by its own speakers.

Future work:

1. **Vocabulary expansion:** Completing domain-specific lexicons (science, technology, law, art).
2. **Texts:** Creating original prose, poetry, and technical documents in Shunaska to stress-test the grammar and surface natural contractions.
3. **Pedagogical materials:** Grammar exercises, pronunciation guides, and a complete dictionary.
4. **Community:** Building a speaker community to observe the natural emergence of registers, shortcuts, and organic exceptions.
5. **Formal study:** Empirical comparison of learning curves vs. Esperanto; cognitive science study of compositional transparency effects.